

## Kao (4452.T): Marketing strategy briefing: Reinforcing competitiveness in AI-driven recommendations harnessing scientific evidence

On July 14, Kao held a marketing strategy briefing featuring Hirofumi Ito, Head of the Marketing Innovation Center, as the main speaker. We confirmed that the scientific evidence possessed by the company is likely to be a strength in agentic commerce, that management's established monitoring (visualization) systems for AI-based recommendations and word-of-mouth can help derive what Kao referred to as the "power to keep being chosen," and that Kao aims to boost its overseas operating margins via an organizational structure that deploys useful systems and HQ expertise globally. We will be watching to see whether the company's source of enhanced competitiveness lies in stronger systems or in its track record of established brand power and sales. We summarize the key takeaways below.

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### Key takeaways (company comments unless otherwise noted)

- **New rules for being chosen in the AI era:** Kao said that before the penetration of AI, it was important to deliver value and information of utility to consumers, whereas in the AI era, it is essential to deliver and accumulate value and information across both consumers and AI. In agentic commerce, the quality of reviews becomes more important than the quantity, and management noted that it plans to harness the scientific evidence it possesses to support its efforts in the AI era.
- **The power to keep being chosen:** Kao said its visualization systems (Global Marketing i-Kao) such as AI recommendation monitoring (wherein it ascertains the status of AI recommendations by country and brand), its VoC Dashboard (Voice of Customer; understanding the penetration rate of social media and word-of-mouth), and its Marketing Initiative Knowledge AI. Kao plans to globally implement a workflow in which it studies the effectiveness of marketing measures and formulates hypotheses based on the status of both AI-driven recommendations and consumer voices. The company aims to deliver what it called "the power to keep being chosen" by leveraging evidence-based proposals and expanding into appropriate touchpoints and areas via a scientific marketing approach for products that have what it described as "exclusive uniqueness."
- **Toward an organization that generates power:** Kao established the Europe and Americas DX Marketing Center. Rolling out HQ and Japanese mechanisms and expertise globally will improve collaboration, speed, and efficiency, per the company. By utilizing the two engines of Global Marketing i-Kao and the Europe

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and Americas DX Marketing Center, management aims to boost operating margins in the overseas global consumer care business, which remain at half the level of Japan.

### Price Target Risks and Methodology - Kao

Our 12-month target price of ¥3,550 is based on a FY12/27E P/E multiple of 23X (the past 10-year average). We are Neutral-rated on the stock. Risks include an acceleration/deceleration in sales, higher/lower operating margins, and increases/decreases in raw materials costs.

|               |                                 |                      |                     |
|---------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------|
| <b>4452.T</b> | 12m Price Target: <b>¥3,550</b> | Price: <b>¥3,293</b> | Upside: <b>7.8%</b> |
|---------------|---------------------------------|----------------------|---------------------|

| Neutral                             | GS Forecast                |         |         |         |         |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------|---------|---------|---------|---------|
|                                     |                            | 12/25   | 12/26E  | 12/27E  | 12/28E  |
| Market cap: ¥3.1tr / \$18.9bn       | Revenue (¥ bn)             | 1,688.6 | 1,756.8 | 1,819.4 | 1,868.5 |
| Enterprise value: ¥2.8tr / \$17.4bn | Op. profit (¥ bn)          | 164.1   | 183.2   | 189.2   | 200.9   |
| 3m ADTV: ¥10.3bn / \$64.6mn         | Op. profit CoE (¥ bn)      | 165.0   | 182.0   | –       | –       |
| Japan                               | EPS (¥)                    | 130.2   | 148.0   | 154.8   | 166.4   |
| Japan Consumer Products             | P/E (X)                    | 24.7    | 22.2    | 21.3    | 19.8    |
| M&A Rank: 3                         | P/B (X)                    | 2.7     | 2.7     | 2.6     | 2.4     |
| Leases incl. in net debt & EV?:     | Dividend yield (%)         | 2.4     | 2.4     | 2.4     | 2.4     |
| Yes                                 | N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X) | (0.9)   | (0.9)   | (0.9)   | (1.0)   |
|                                     | CROCI (%)                  | 9.6     | 9.8     | 9.7     | 9.8     |
|                                     |                            | 3/26    | 6/26E   | 9/26E   | 12/26E  |
|                                     | EPS (¥)                    | 34.3    | 32.5    | 37.5    | 43.8    |

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 14 Jul 2026 close.

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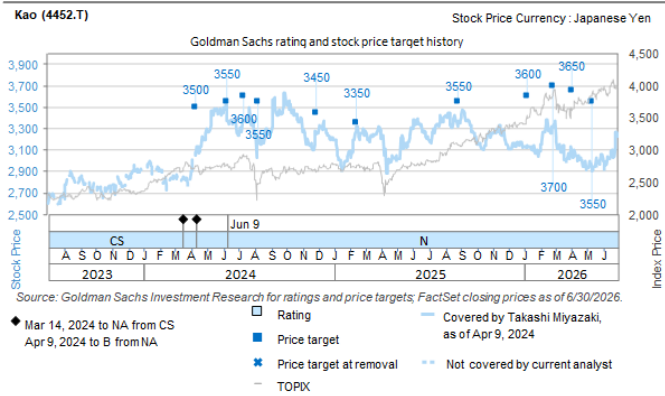
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Kao (4452.T)

| Date of report | Target price (¥) | Closing price (¥) |
|----------------|------------------|-------------------|
| 12-May-26      | 7,100            | 2,905             |
| 02-Apr-26      | 7,300            | 3,091             |
| 25-Feb-26      | 7,400            | 3,325             |
| 08-Jan-26      | 7,200            | 3,128             |
| 28-Aug-25      | 7,100            | 3,369             |
| 12-Feb-25      | 6,700            | 3,277             |
| 28-Nov-24      | 6,900            | 3,269             |
| 08-Aug-24      | 7,100            | 3,165             |
| 11-Jul-24      | 7,200            | 3,386             |
| 09-Jun-24      | 7,100            | 3,514             |
| 09-Apr-24      | 7,000            | 3,079             |

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